

From: motherofpekes@icloud.com 
Subject: Re: Formal Request for Review of Bitless Bridle Prohibition – Documented Exclusion from EA-Affiliated Dressage Event
Date: 19 February 2026 at 9:48 am
To: Dressage Dressage@equestrian.org.au



Dear Caiwen,

Thank you for your detailed response and clarification regarding the current EA Dressage rules.

My EA membership number is: 1050127.

I understand that EA currently aligns with FEI rules and that bitless bridles are not permitted under 5.11(k). However, I would like to address the point raised regarding the absence of established judging guidelines for horses competing bitless.

The core Dressage judging criteria—rhythm, suppleness, contact, impulsion, straightness, and collection—are biomechanical and behavioural outcomes. They are not inherently dependent on the presence of a bit. Judges assess:

- The quality and regularity of gaits
- Elasticity and suppleness of the back
- Acceptance of the contact and connection from hind leg to hand
- Self-carriage and balance
- Straightness through the body
- Degree of collection appropriate to the level

None of these principles require oral hardware in order to be evaluated. A horse working correctly into a bitless bridle can still demonstrate acceptance of contact through consistent connection, longitudinal balance, and poll alignment, just as is currently assessed.

If the primary barrier is the absence of formalised judging guidance specific to bitless competition, I am prepared to draft proposed judging guidelines for consideration. These would:

- Clarify how “contact” is defined in the absence of a bit
- Maintain alignment with the existing EA Training Scale
- Ensure judging remains outcome-based rather than equipment-based
- Address stewarding and equipment inspection considerations
- Include risk management and transitional implementation recommendations

I am also willing to offer my time and expertise to assist in the development or

~~and I would also be happy to assist the Committee in considering further examination of this issue~~

review process should the Committee consider further examination of this issue valuable.

In addition, may I ask whether EA would consider a limited pilot program whereby riders could compete bitless Hors Concours (HC) within existing classes? The judges are already engaged, the infrastructure is already in place, and HC entries would not affect placings or rankings. Such a pilot could:

- Provide practical judging experience without altering official results
- Generate observational data to inform any future policy decisions
- Offer increased entries and exposure for organising committees
- Allow EA to assess welfare, presentation, and judging consistency in a controlled environment

A structured pilot would seem to provide an evidence-based pathway forward, rather than requiring a binary decision in principle alone.

I appreciate that this matter was recently reviewed. However, given the increasing welfare discussions internationally and ongoing evolution of equipment regulations, I believe it is reasonable to revisit the issue with structured governance support and practical evaluation.

I will prepare a formal proposal through my State Discipline Committee in accordance with the required process.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Kind regards,
Paula Lasersohn

From: Dressage <Dressage@equestrian.org.au>
Sent: Wednesday, February 18, 2026 3:50 PM
To: Motherofpekes@icloud.com <Motherofpekes@icloud.com>
Subject: FW: Formal Request for Review of Bitless Bridle Prohibition – Documented Exclusion from EA-Affiliated Dressage Event

Hello Paula,

Could you please provide your EA membership number?

Bitless bridles are not allowed in EA Dressage competitions even unofficial and HC, as per EA Dressage rules -

https://www.equestrian.org.au/sites/default/files/EA%20Dressage%20Rule%20Book%20January%202026_0.pdf:

- *5.11 k) bitless bridles are not permitted*
- *5.12 table of equipment permitted/not permitted - Bitless bridle - NOT permitted at an event or venue The wearing of any of the following at an event will entail elimination*
- *Annex E Elimination, technical faults, penalties and deductions – Will entail*

elimination: 5.11 – Wearing a bitless bridle
and the EA National Dressage Committee (EADC) would not grant an exemption for a bitless bridle to be used.

For any proposed rule changes, submissions must first be made to your State Discipline Committee. The committee will review the proposal and, if supported, will then forward it to the National Discipline Committee for consideration and voting.

For your information, requests to include bitless bridles within the EA Dressage rules were recently reviewed by both the State Dressage Committees and the EA National Dressage Committee. These requests were not supported, as the EA Dressage Committee has elected to align with FEI Dressage rules in relation to bitless bridles, and there are no established judging guidelines on judging horses competing bitless in Dressage.

If you are a current EA member, you are welcome to submit a proposal through your State Discipline Committee; however, please be aware that there is a strong likelihood the request would not be supported, as this matter has been reviewed recently and a decision was made not to permit bitless bridles at this time.

I believe Pony Club allow bitless bridles, so that may be another alternative competition pathway for you to look into.

Thank you,

<https://tack.fei.org/equipment/ac0258c2-34ca-46eb-b776-d6f7d93aa912>

FEI FEDERATION EQUESTRE INTERNATIONALE

Home — Rules — Rules — Bitless bridles

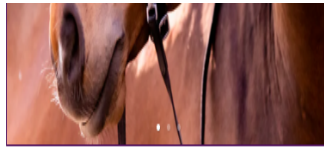
BITLESS BRIDLES

Discipline	Permitted
Jumping	Yes
Dressage	No
Para Dressage	No
Eventing	Yes
Driving	No
Para Driving	No
Endurance	Yes
Vaulting	No

Not Permitted



FEI TACK EQUIPMENT REQUIREMENTS - DRESSAGE



Kind regards,

Caiwen

Caiwen Cusworth

**Sport Development Officer
Equestrian Australia**

+61 2 8762 7711 | Mailing address: PO Box 673 SYDNEY MARKETS NSW 2129 AUSTRALIA

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From: Equestrian Info <info@equestrian.org.au>

Sent: Wednesday, 18 February 2026 11:08 AM

To: Dressage <Dressage@equestrian.org.au>

Cc: motherofpekes@icloud.com

Subject: Fw: Formal Request for Review of Bitless Bridle Prohibition – Documented Exclusion from EA-Affiliated Dressage Event

Hi Caiwen,

Please see below.

Kind Regards,

**Tinesha Carey (she/her)
Member Services Officer
Equestrian Australia**

E: tinesha.carey@equestrian.org.au

W: www.equestrian.org.au

P: +61 2 8762 7704



In the spirit of reconciliation Equestrian Australia acknowledges the Traditional Custodians of country throughout Australia and their connections to land, sea, and community. We pay our respect to their Elders past and present and extend that respect to all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples today.



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From: motherofpekes@icloud.com <motherofpekes@icloud.com>
Sent: Friday, 13 February 2026 9:48 PM
To: Equestrian Info <info@equestrian.org.au>; admin@dressagensw.com.au <admin@dressagensw.com.au>
Cc: honsecretary@dressagensw.com.au <honsecretary@dressagensw.com.au>; jeff.oliver@3dux.com.au <jeff.oliver@3dux.com.au>; treasurer@dressagensw.com.au <treasurer@dressagensw.com.au>; Paula Lasersohn <motherofpekes@icloud.com>
Subject: Formal Request for Review of Bitless Bridle Prohibition – Documented Exclusion from EA-Affiliated Dressage Event

You don't often get email from motherofpekes@icloud.com. [Learn why this is important](#)

Dear Equestrian Australia and Equestrian NSW,

I am writing to formally request review of the EA Dressage Rule prohibiting bitless bridles, and to seek clarification following my exclusion from an EA-affiliated dressage competition in December 2025.

I entered Freya and Leo in Prelim 1.2 and Novice 1.2 at the NCEC Members Christmas Dressage Event (EA-affiliated). Prior to the competition, I informed the organiser that I ride bitless and offered multiple options to comply with the rules while still participating, including:

- Competing Hors Concours
- Being eliminated after riding in order to receive my test sheets
- Riding purely for feedback and leaving

Initially, the organiser indicated this may be possible.

Subsequently, I was advised by phone and email that I would not be permitted to ride at all, and my entry was refunded. The reason provided was that bitless bridles are prohibited under EA dressage rules and that allowing me to ride would “affect insurance.”

Notably, I was also advised that had there been a show jumping competition on the same day, I would have been permitted to ride bitless on the same premises in that discipline.

This highlights a significant inconsistency:

- Bitless riding is permitted under EA rules in show jumping
- The same horse and rider may be present on the same grounds
- Jumping is objectively higher risk than dressage
- Yet bitless participation is prohibited only in dressage

This strongly suggests the restriction is not based on safety, but on discipline-specific rule definition.

I acknowledge that current EA Dressage Rules prohibit bitless bridles. My concern is whether this prohibition remains reasonable and proportionate given modern understanding of equine cognition and welfare, and EA’s stated principle that the welfare of the horse is paramount.

The EA National Dressage Rules state that horse welfare must take precedence over all other demands, that tack must be designed and fitted to avoid pain or injury, and that actions causing unnecessary discomfort — including to the mouth — constitute abuse. The rules also define the object of dressage as producing a “happy athlete through harmonious education.” I am seeking clarification as to how a mandatory mouth-based control device aligns with these stated principles, particularly where humane, steward-inspectable alternatives exist.

I therefore formally request:

1. Confirmation of the specific Dressage Rule clause prohibiting bitless bridles.
2. Written clarification as to whether this prohibition is based solely on EA rules or on insurer requirements.
3. If insurance is cited, provision of the relevant insurer name and policy clause requiring exclusion of bitless riders.
4. Confirmation of whether any exemption, dispensation, or pilot process exists.
5. Consideration of a structured pilot or HC class permitting steward-inspected bitless bridles to assess safety, judging integrity, and welfare outcomes.

...to ensure safety, judging integrity, and humane treatment.

I am not requesting removal of traditional equipment. I am requesting inclusion of humane alternatives where horses are trained through clarity and cooperation rather than mandatory mouth-based control.

This issue is gaining increasing attention internationally, including recent widely discussed cases involving junior riders excluded for riding bitless. At the same time, public scrutiny of equestrian sport is intensifying, including calls to remove equestrian disciplines from the Olympic Games.

I believe this represents both a risk and an opportunity for dressage in Australia.

I would welcome constructive dialogue and am willing to provide evidence, veterinary perspectives, and practical demonstration of safe bitless competition readiness.

Thank you for your consideration. I look forward to your formal response.

Kind regards,

Paula Lasersohn
ACT

0438 401 772

Motherofpekes@icloud.com